

Statement of the Hon. Breckinridge Long

The Committee on Foreign Affairs of the House of Representatives has recently released to the public a statement made by the Hon. Breckinridge Long, on Friday, November 25, 1943, in the course of hearings the Committee was then holding on House Resolutions 350 and 352 "Providing for the Establishment by the Executive of a Commission to Effectuate the Rescue of the Jewish People of Europe." The statement is quite important as one of the first official reports since the Bermuda Conference on the developments with regard to the problem of rescuing the Jewish people of Europe; and, within the limits dictated by prudence, it reveals certain significant details. Yet, on the whole, it is a statement which can only be read with mixed feelings, compounded more largely of bewilderment and regret than of satisfaction.

In common with other Jewish organizations and with a good many non-Jews the World Jewish Congress has proposed that *special, extraordinary measures* be taken to rescue the Jews of Europe, above and beyond the measures devised for other refugees.

The reason for this demand is the harsh, incontrovertible fact that the Jews alone, by virtue of their being Jews and without any other requisite cause, have been condemned to extermination by the Germans; and that wherever the present German rulers exercise the necessary degree of control, the policy of extermination is being ruthlessly carried out. *In other words, it is already a notorious fact that the surviving Jews of Europe will be killed by the Germans at the first opportunity; and this being known, extraordinary measures are called for.* The situation is analogous in many ways to the case of patriots in the Lofoten Islands or members of underground movements who aid Commando units or commit other acts of resistance and who become known to the Germans, and thus are placed in imminent danger of death. In the case of those patriots in the Lofoten Islands and elsewhere the Allies have frequently taken extraordinary measures to ensure their safety. All the Jews within reach of German power, whether they have incurred Nazi displeasure by specific "offenses" in addition to being Jews or not, are in such imminent danger—not of oppression such as it common to all the subjugated peoples but of death. It would seem natural therefore that extraordinary measures should be adopted in their behalf.

Mr. Long's reaction to this plea, as recorded in the transcript of his remarks before the House Foreign Affairs Committee, is no less than shocking. With all possible allowances for inexactitude of expression in an oral declaration, we cannot understand how such statements as the following could have been uttered (p. 32 of the transcript):

... We have been interested in refugees; and I think there has been some indisposition on the part of some officers to accept the thought that the American Government ought to specialize and make it particularly direct that we are interested only in the Jews. *We have felt from the start that we could not exclude other persons from our governmental and official activities.**

And further on, in reply to a question by Representative Karl E. Mundt of South Dakota, Mr. Long declared (p. 45):

... the situation has come to a state of publicity today where I think the Jewish interests have emphasized the fate of the Jews as such . . . the State Department's policy I think must be that we cannot exclude persons from our sympathy and our sympathetic attention if they are not Jews. I think we must treat all persons, irrespective of their race, religion, or political beliefs, in the same way.

It is with a deep feeling of shame—shame for our apparent inability to make our honest intentions understood, and shame that an outstanding representative of the United States should so misunderstand them—that we must make our attitude plain once again. We are in favor of aid to all refugees and oppressed people; *over and above that, but not as a substitute for such aid*, we plead for extraordinary aid for all people known to be in imminent danger of death. Whenever the occasion arises that such danger threatens a particular group, we wish to see such extraordinary measures taken—as, on occasion, they have been. *There is no need for a special occasion to invoke such measures on behalf of European Jews, since death stares them in the face constantly.*

Mr. Long's strictures are directed, no doubt, particularly to the activities of American Jews—although the plea for special measures to aid the Jews of Europe has by no means been monopolized by American or any other Jews. It seems necessary, therefore, to document the attitude of American

*Italics in all quotations ours.—Ed.